

Reinventing the budget laptop

According to Primebook, budget laptops simply haven't been good enough

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For years, the affordable laptop market has had an odd contradiction at its centre. India is a price-sensitive market, students and first-time PC buyers form a large potential base, and smartphones have proved that volume can come from the lower end of the price ladder. Yet, in laptops, the volume has traditionally skewed upwards. Chitranshu Mahant, Co-Founder and CEO of Primebook, believes the reason is simple: budget laptops have not been good enough.

Mahant framed Primebook's Android laptop bet not as an affordability play, but as an attempt to fix what he sees as a broken entry-level

modest ratings, battery life that can fall from 7-8 hours to 3-4 hours over time, and limited usability beyond browsing or light Word, Excel and PPT workloads.

That is the gap Primebook wants to occupy. Instead of trying to make Windows work better on weak hardware, the company is taking Android, stripping away Google dependency, and turning it into a desktop-style operating system for laptop hardware. It is an unusual pitch in a market

where Windows remains the default mental model for a laptop, but Primebook sees that as the point. It wants to build a new category around smartphone-native users who are buying their first serious computing device.

Why Android became the starting point

Mahant said Primebook began its journey in 2018, at a time when the company saw workflows shifting away from laptops and towards smartphones. He argues that this shift partly explains why laptops have seen slow growth over the past decade. Now, however, the arrival of

AI-led workflows is changing the equation again. Smartphones, in Primebook's view, are not always the right form factor for those tasks, especially for first-time laptop users who want a larger screen, keyboard and productivity-friendly environment.

Primebook's thesis rests on three pillars: performance, battery life and app access. Mahant claims that on similar hardware, PrimeOS is around 1.5 times faster than Windows in the same price bracket. He also claims that a PrimeOS-powered Primebook can deliver 14 hours of video playback at 80 percent brightness in the Rs 25,000 hardware bracket. The third piece is the Android app ecosystem, which gives the

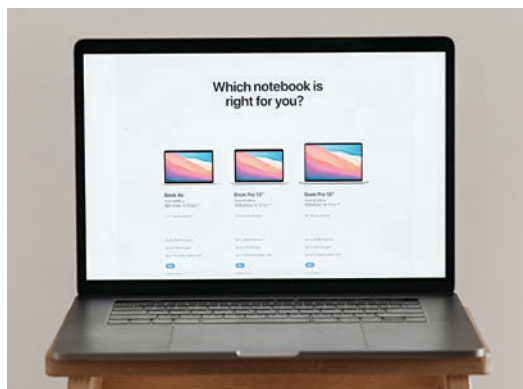
machine access to millions of apps that are already familiar to smartphone-first users.

This is also why Linux was not the primary choice, despite its technical proximity to Android. Mahant said Primebook's target group is made up of Android-native, smartphone-first users in the 15-25 age bracket, and for them, the Android app ecosystem mattered more. Primebook uses Android open source, but does not rely on the Google Play Store or Google Play services. Instead, it has its own store, services and browser.

That's where Primebook tries to make a distinction. Primebook is not merely selling an Android device with a keyboard. It is trying to own enough of the software layer to control the experience, the app store, the file manager, the browser, and eventually, the AI and cloud layers that sit on top of it. **d**



Chitranshu Mahant
Co-Founder and CEO
of Primebook



laptop experience. The company's argument is that many sub-Rs 30,000 Windows laptops, suffer from poor performance, limited battery life and a compromised app experience. "Budget laptops are fundamentally broken," he said, pointing to slow performance,

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